

but that their relationship was not consummated. Mountbatten's official biographer, Philip Ziegler, said in an interview that only someone standing at the end of the bed would have known if Nehru and Edwina had ever had sex. But Tunzelmann prefers to imply that there was a physical relationship. After all that makes a better story. Lord Mountbatten's colourful versions of events make good stories too. She quotes a friend telling him, "Dickie, you are so crooked that if you swallowed a nail you would shit a corkscrew."

Tunzelmann still makes full use of the Viceroy's reports and in the portions of the book dealing with the integration of the princely states into India and Pakistan, her preference for the colourful is clear. When, immediately after signing the Instrument of Accession, the Maharaja of Jodhpur held a revolver to V.P. Menon's head, Menon records him saying, "I refuse to accept your dictation." But Tunzelmann chooses the Viceroy's version, with the Maharaja screaming that he would shoot Menon "down like a dog if he be-



trayed the starving people of Jodhpur". Writing on the same subject, Guha quotes Menon and his book provides a more balanced account of the integration of the North-West Frontier Province and the princely states.

Tunzelmann could have finished her story when the Mountbattens left India, but instead she traces the lives of the three in this "ménage à trois" to their deaths—first Edwina, then Nehru and finally Mountbatten. Their end, not the end of Empire, is indeed the natural conclusion of this book. ■



A Kingdom of Her Own

A collage of myriad perspectives, Thapa's stories offer a glimpse of the Nepalese reality through the tapestry of time and change



TILLED EARTH: STORIES
by MANJUSHREE THAPA
Penguin
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■ **By Geeta Doctor**

They fall upon the page as clean and fresh as newly driven snow on the glittering slopes of Nepal's fabled mountains. They offer tantalising glimpses of the Himalayan kingdom, at times as magnificent as the sudden glimpse of an ice-covered peak in the distance, at other times as homely and pungent as the dung that lies on the road of her mountain paths. Manjushree Thapa's stories fall into the category that the Japanese call 'palm-of-the-hand' stories. Some of them are just a page long, delicate or witty sketches that trace a mood, or a moment. Others have the lingering charm of novellas, fully glimpsed meditations on a person's entire life.

What makes them intriguing is the way Thapa changes her perspective so deftly from one narrative voice to another—from a woman's view-point to that of a man, from a young Nepali translator teaching an American aid-worker to a seasoned bureaucrat—that you can hardly get a glimpse of her. It's as if she were whirling her telescope around from the peaks to the valleys of

her native country pointing out the rhododendrons from the camellias, or trailing through the streets of Kathmandu, only to show you that nothing is as permanent as the landscape of the human heart.

Unlike so many observers of the changing pattern of life in the Third World, Thapa does not dwell on giving merely an anthropological view. Like the old woodcarver who comes down in the curtain raiser to peer at a once-familiar landscape that had been filled with the wooden doors and windows of the houses he had carved, and is defeated by the plenitude of progress. The garden has been landscaped with all manner of exotic flowers and trees that drip their blooms upon him are no longer familiar. "A pearl-white butterfly fluttered past him." And with that the past itself seems to go. Thapa's skill is in evoking the passage of time and recording these tectonic shifts of cultural disruption with an eye that is both clinical and as delicate as the flutter of a butterfly's wing.

The best stories are those that deal with the dreaded East-West encounters, the fatal attraction that both binds two individuals from two very different backgrounds and divides them. Thapa performs this dance macabre with a certain wit and self-knowledge. There is both a sense of despair and celebration that is brilliantly balanced. ■